



In the 1996 World Cup quarterfinal, you famously scored 22 runs off one Waqar Younis over — a knock that has become part of cricket folklore. When you meet Waqar now, do you ever remind him of that innings?

It's a long story that began in 1988 when we played Under-19 cricket in Pakistan. We've been great friends since then and even played league cricket together in England. Waqar often jokes, since he's gotten me out more times, '*sau sunar ki, ek lohar ki*' (one powerful blow is worth a hundred smaller ones). Sometimes, you have those perfect days, and that happened to be one of them on the ideal stage.

What do you expect from India in its upcoming five-match Test series against Australia?

I think we'll do well. We might not perform well enough to reach the World Test Championship final since that would require four wins out of

five, which could be tough. Still, I believe we should come back with a series win. We are a better side.

Even though India won the last two series in Australia, the Aussies say they're ready for us, especially after India's 0-3 loss to New Zealand at home. What challenges will India face there?

They always have something to say. It has always been one of their strengths. They play with your mind. Our cricket has changed. Earlier, we would go to Australia once in eight or nine years, so, in a side of 15, there were just two or three players who had travelled or played in those conditions. Now you have emerging teams going there; every two or three years you go to Australia. So, our team is well equipped. When you have nothing to lose, that is when you will be dangerous. When you have lost 0-3 here [against New Zealand], going there you have nothing to lose and everything to gain.

Impact player: "Rishabh Pant is freakish; he is brilliant, and as long as he's playing, he will be the best," said Ajay Jadeja in a conversation with Sportstar's consulting editor Vijay Lokapally at the Sportstar Sports Conclave — Focus Rajasthan.

R.V. MOORTHY

Rishabh Pant has exceptional talent and the ability to turn a match on his own. Do you think he could become the greatest Indian cricketer of all time?

He is freakish, brilliant and as long as he's playing, he will be the best. He is a genius, no doubt, but you fear these geniuses. You do not know what they do next. But he should stay like this; otherwise, he would not be a genius. This is a fine line as a coach. How do you tame a genius? You got to enjoy them as long as it lasts. As soon as you try to tame them, you take away their brilliance. It is a double-edged sword.